ment subsequently handed over the contract for sand mining, storage and sale to the Jaypee Group's Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd (JPVL), which had no experience in the field; that agreement expired on May 2 this year. The TDP further claims that JPVL passed on the contract to another company called Turnkey, which opted out of it in July 2022 following differences over profit-sharing. Since then, local YSRCP leaders have been making money through the sand mafia, competing with one another, the TDP says. The party also cites JPVL's quarterly financial statement in July that the company submitted to the Bombay Stock Exchange and the National Stock Exchange. "The report revealed that JPVL had hired sub-contractors. The government was in a state of denial until then," says TDP spokesman Pattabhi Ram Kommareddy.

After nearly a week of conspicuous silence, the YSRCP government finally responded to these accusations on August 31. Peddireddy Ramachandra Reddy, the state minister of mines and geology, categorically stated that sand is being mined in a transparent manner, and that though the government had entrusted the activity only to JPVL, it had no links with the sub-contractors that JPVL roped in later.

Counter-barbs were traded, too. The minister alleged that it was illegal mining during the TDP rule between 2014 and 2019 that had forced the NGT to impose a Rs 100 crore penalty on the government. He also accused Lokesh, Naidu's son, of getting Rs 500 crore a year through the scam during the TDP rule. "Now, the government earns over Rs 750 crore a year on sand, while there was no revenue from it during the TDP term," Reddy told media.

Naidu has promised that if his party comes to power, it will order an inquiry into the loot and punish guilty officials. Given the escalating campaign, the least the YSRCP regime can do for now is come up with a more comprehensive explanation about the charges instead of just bandying words and hoping for the din to die down with time. ■



WELL-PROWLED PATHS
Tiger reserves in Maharashtra's Vidarbha have reached their carrying capacities

AJAY TIWARI

TIGER TRANSLOCATION

SHIFTING STRIPES

By Dhaval Kulkarni

Tiger numbers in Maharashtra represent a roaring success of conservation efforts. The estimated number of big cats in the state in 2022 is 444—up from 312 in 2018 and 190 in 2014. The state has the fourth largest population of tigers after Madhya Pradesh (785), Karnataka (563) and Uttarakhand (560). The rise is due to better habitat management and enhanced protection measures. However, the spread of tigers in Maharashtra is lopsided—they are concentrated in the Vidarbha region, especially eastern Vidarbha, which is part of the central Indian landscape. The Brahmapuri and Chandrapur forest divisions in Chandrapur district are estimated to have around 120 tigers, outnumbering several tiger projects. Growth in the tiger population here has led to a rise in man-animal conflict. Since 2017, around 250 people have been killed by tigers in the state, with 76 deaths, the highest in recent years, occurring in 2022.

While Vidarbha bristles with tigers, western Maharashtra offers a stark contrast. The Sahyadri Tiger Reserve in the Western Ghats, which spans an area of 1,165 sq. km, has no breeding/ resident tigers. The reserve covers 600 sq. km of core forest land and 565 sq. km of buffer